



In a season of cyclones and weeping skies over the subcontinent, Port Blair was defiantly sunny as we boarded the ferry to Swaraj Deep.

It used to take six hours, but now a high-speed luxury catamaran gets us there in two. At that speed, it is impossible for passengers to catch the sea breeze on the stern, so we must sit safely in the cabin. Still, the windows were large and there were samosas and tea on board, and in the already slanting sun the massive South Andaman Island bounded our western view, a spine of dense forest rising from the sea. The faster ferry has made it easier to reach the islands of Ritchie's Archipelago, a site rich in wildlife and rare beauty. Swaraj Dweep, once called Havelock Island, is the largest of these, and one of only two that accommodate tourists. No two beaches are quite the same on Swaraj Dweep. On the serene Vijaynagar Beach bordering the Tilar Siro resort, it is a shock to find lush vegetation just metres from the white coral sand, fringed with sea lettuce and pandanus trees crowned with fruit. It is all the gift of the continual wash of alluvial deposits from volcanic rock and calcium from dead coral, so that the wild ginger and kapok we know from the mainland grow enormous here. Baby waves lap at a peaceful shore, and toddlers build their sand castles in the shelter of kneeling tamanu trees. In the evening, guests gather over tea and pakoras to watch the moon silver the water.

Most of them turn out for the early sunrise, too, carrying their phone cameras or their yoga mats, or just holding hands. But about mid-day, the tide goes out, and the view is unrecognisable. A picture-postcard scene has become a landscape to explore. Lumps of dead coral rise from the sand, and the dawn's unvarying sea now ranges from ivory, through shades of aqua green, to a ribbon of intense blue in the distance. You can walk one kilometre into the sea at low tide, and the guided intertidal walk is a sort of kindergarten for people who want to see into the ocean.

The walk is quite a workout. The water is at our ankles at first, but once it is knee deep, we struggle to stay upright. We stumble into holes in the sand and stub our toes on coral, still gamely pushing on. Much of the coral is dead here, because of the 2004 tsunami and increasingly hot summers, but it is coming back to life. Against a background of mostly pore coral, fingers of fire coral are easiest to find, and if we look close we can spot brain coral and even honeycomb coral. Our guide probes into the gaps with a rod to tease out sea creatures. If you stand silent and still long enough, they venture out on their own. Here are juvenile sergeant majors, angel fish, parrot fish, and rainbow fish. We see moon crabs in dusky blue and yellow, a striped butterfly fish, and a batfish drifting like a leaf. Blink-and-you-miss-it feather duster worms emerge, small red wounds in the sand that flower into many layers and, when you peer closer, disappear. An octopus pretending to be sand shoots away when disturbed.

Don't touch anything, we are

UNDER THE SEA

Snorkelling brings you closer to the uncounted life forms in the archipelago, which has some of the world's best diving spots



